

The Mom Test — Executive Founder Guide

Author: Rob Fitzpatrick • Key Principles for Customer Discovery & Validation

The Core Golden Rule:

Talk about their life instead of your idea. Ask about specifics in the past instead of generics or opinions about the future. Talk less and listen more.

1. The Three Rules of The Mom Test

- **Rule 1:** Talk about their life, not your idea. (Ask what tools broke for them last week).
- **Rule 2:** Ask about specifics in the past, not generics or opinions about the future. (Never ask "Would you buy a tool that fixes APIs?").
- **Rule 3:** Talk less and listen more. (Let CTOs vent about their pain).

2. Good Questions vs Bad Questions

-  **Bad:** "Do you think an automated API repair tool is a good idea?" (They will politely say yes).
-  **Good:** "How do you currently handle breaking SDK updates in your codebase?"
-  **Bad:** "How much would you pay for a solution like Repairo?"
-  **Good:** "How much money or developer hours did the last breaking API update cost your team?"

3. How to Spot Compliments vs Real Commitments

- **Compliments are Useless:** "I love this!", "This looks awesome!" mean nothing without commitment.
- **Real Commitments:** Time commitment (agreeing to a 2nd deep-dive meeting), Reputation commitment (introducing you to their VP of Eng), or Money (pre-orders/LOIs).